stipulated: ‘In conformity with the admitted principle of suzerainty of China over Thibet, Great Britain and Russia engage not to enter into negotiations with Thibet except through the intermediary of the Chinese Government.’

In Simla, both the Lonchen Shatra and Henry McMahon, were extremely well prepared. The Tibetan representative was equipped with virtually every conceivable document—all the sheets were carefully stacked between wooden slats and wrapped in colourful Chinese silk in the customary Tibetan manner. Almost all historical books and documents had exotic names: *The Feast of Pleasure for the Perfected Youths* gave an account of the early boundaries between China and Tibet, compiled at the time of the fifth Dalai Lama. *The Golden Tree, the World’s Sole Ornament* gave information pertaining to even older boundaries. There were registers of houses, monasteries, tenants, landlords, taxes, incomes; registers of doorsteps and fireplaces, each doorstep and fireplace connoting a family; bonds of allegiance; military lists, and agreements showing the quotas of troops to be supplied by various districts; laws, regulations, legal judgments and executive orders; these and other proofs of actual administration were brought down from Tibet to support their claims.

The British on the other hand, had most of the territory under their control mapped out. Apart from a plethora of surveys by various expeditions, McMahon had access to Bailey and Morshead’s recent survey that painted a clear picture of the situation on either side of the border in the extreme east. The British also had Claude White’s equally precise survey of the Sikkim Plateau (where the Teesta River originated), East Sikkim, the Chumbi Valley and Bhutan. While the border with Nepal was well defined, the northern border that stretched from Kumaon all the way to the Aksai Chin was also a relatively known entity. The only unexplored region was the gap between the upper reaches of the Subansiri eastwards to the Kameng River (Bokar region).

On the map, the lower thick line running east-west formed the McMahon Line between India and Tibet on the one hand and India and Burma on the other. A second north-south continuous line indicated the boundary between China and Tibet. The territory lying between the thick line and the dotted line was referred to as Inner Tibet. It is significant to note that when the Chinese later raised an objection to the Simla Convention, it was only regarding the position of Inner Tibet and had nothing to do with the demarcation of the McMahon Line. Interestingly, in